SEVEN

The Grey Door

NELL · DAY 23,235 · TUESDAY 26 MAY 2026

I WATCHED THE door for forty minutes before I crossed the road.

I'd lived opposite it for six years. Now I stood at my kitchen window with a cold tea and made an inventory, because that's what I do when I'm frightened. One grey door. One brass letterbox, polished. A hanging basket that was watered at the same time every evening, by a man who never had visitors. In six years I'd seen one van outside that house, and I hadn't looked at the logo.

His light was on at night. Every night. When I got up at three to check a date, there it was across the road, one yellow square, upstairs, facing mine. I'd found that companionable. I'd once raised my mug to it.

WHEN YOU ARE READY THE DOOR IS GREY.

I put the letter in my bag, and the notebook, and the keycard, I don't know why. I wrote *Gone across the road* on the back of an envelope and put it under the salt. Then I took it out, added the time, and put it back. I thought about ringing Danny. I'd have had to tell him what I was afraid of, and I'd had a thought about Danny

at this same window on Saturday that I still hadn't finished being ashamed of.

The road was empty. It's eleven paces across. A woman with a pushchair went past the end of it and didn't look round, and I noticed that, and noticed myself noticing.

There was no bell. I lifted the letterbox flap and let it drop, twice.

Nothing. Then, a long way back in the house, a chair. Slow steps on a hard floor. They stopped on the other side of the door and stayed there, and I could hear someone breathing through his nose and looking at me through the frosted panel, a shape and a shape.

A chain slid. The door opened as far as a slipper.

"Is it the drips?" he said.

* * *

GRAHAM TULL WAS seventy-four and wore a tie to water plants. He'd been a driving examiner for thirty-eight years, and he looked at me as if I'd just clipped a kerb.

"Only I've had the postman," he said. "I've offered to move it six inches. He says it's the principle."

I said it wasn't the drips. I said I was from across the road. He said he knew who I was, I was number nineteen, second floor, and I'd better come in, because I looked as if I'd had a fright and the kettle had just boiled.

I went in. I'd like that noted. A letter had told me about a door, and a man I didn't know had told me to come inside, and I went.

The hall smelled of compost and furniture polish. He sent me up the stairs to the front room and went off to the kitchen, and I heard the tap. There was one armchair, pulled up to the window. There was a small table beside it with a pair of binoculars on it. And beside the binoculars lay a hardback notebook, open, with a pencil in the gutter.

I knew I shouldn't. I've never once in my life been able to not read a column.

Dates down the left. Then two columns of times, in a small square hand.

Sat 23 May. 01:40. 04:15. Sun 24 May. 02:05. 05:30. Mon 25 May. 00:50. —

I turned back a page. Then a dozen pages, with the blood going out of my fingers. April. March. The columns ran on and on without a gap. I found the night I started the blog.

Mon 20 Apr. 21:10. 03:10.

I'd pressed *publish* at ten past three. I had never told anyone that.

"Sugar?" Graham said behind me.

He was in the doorway with a tray. He looked at the book in my hands, and then at me, and he didn't hurry, and he didn't put the tray down.

"That's you," he said.

I couldn't have run. My knees had gone. I said, in a voice I'd last used on a depot manager, "Who do you give it to?"

"Give it to?"

"The book. Who reads it?"

He considered the question honestly, as he must have considered ten thousand three-point turns. "Nobody reads it," he said. "It's your light."

He set the tray on the sill, took the notebook out of my hands, and closed it.

"I don't sleep. I haven't since Maureen. It's a long night, you know, on your own, when you've nothing to mark. Then a few years back I noticed you didn't sleep either. So when yours comes on I put mine on, and when yours goes off I go up." He squared the book to the edge of the table. "I write it down because I wrote everything down for thirty-eight years, and I can't seem to stop. You had a bad fortnight in the middle of this month. I nearly came over."

Across the road, a floor above us, I could see my own kitchen window. Somewhere behind it was an envelope under the salt.

"You raised your mug to me once," Graham said. "Two years last November. I've got it in the book."

I sat down on the arm of his chair and, to my enormous embarrassment, began to laugh, and then it wasn't laughing, and he gave me the tea with two sugars and looked politely at his fuchsias until I'd finished.

* * *

I DID CHECK. I want that on the record as well.

I took the letter out on the step and held the grey band against his door. In daylight it wasn't even close. The door was warm, with a bit of brown in it, the colour of a wet pavement. The band was cool and flat and had come from nowhere. I asked him how long the door had been that colour anyway, and he told me, and it took until two o'clock.

Maureen had chosen it in 1998, because it wouldn't show the dirt. It showed everything. He'd told her so. They'd argued about it for twenty-two years, happily, on and off, the way other couples argue about money, and he had always maintained that a front door ought to be yellow. In the shed behind the house he showed me three unopened tins of yellow gloss, each with a different year on it in that small square hand. He bought one every spring. He got it home, and he put it on the shelf.

"It's a terrible colour," he said, looking at the door from the path. "She was quite wrong."

He gave me soup from a tin, and a fuchsia cutting in a yoghurt pot, and he told me I was gripping my bag too high. I crossed the road at ten past two, eleven paces, with a whole day gone and a plant. There was no chair in that house but his own. Nobody had been waiting for me. I took the envelope out from under the salt and put it in the bin, under some other things.

The doorbell went at half past three: two short rings.

"You've got a plant," Danny said. He'd seen it on my windowsill from the van. Then he saw my face, and I told him, because it was that or lie down on the floor. By the time I got to *is it the drips* he had to hold on to the door frame.

"You knocked on *Graham*."

"The letter said—"

"You thought Graham Tull was the Illuminati. Graham, who failed my Kath twice for not checking her mirrors." He wiped his eyes and took out his van keys and began turning them over in his hand, which he does when he's stopped finding something funny. "Get your coat. You want grey doors, I'll show you grey doors."

* * *

THERE WERE A hundred and twelve of them on Wharf Road. Four storeys of deck access, the same council grey on every landing, the paint coming off in the same long curls. We stood on the third-floor walkway with the wind coming up from the old basin, and Danny let me look at them for as long as it took.

"Go on," he said. "Knock on one. This one needs it."

The boy who answered was six foot two and in his socks, and behind him the flat was full of boxes that nobody had quite finished packing or quite begun.

"Jack," Danny said.

"It's Jordan."

"It's Jack when you owe me twenty quid. This is Nell."

He'd picked the name at sixteen. Danny explained the joke on the way back to the van and I wish he hadn't, but it had come out of the sort of corner of the internet that boys find, it had made the whole estate laugh, and it stuck, until the real name was only on the paperwork. Everyone called him Jordan, his friends, the feeds, the girl at the chip shop. He stayed Jack to me. I never decided that. He just looked like somebody who ought to have one person who'd got it right.

He looked at me for a while before he let me in.

"You're Coyle's," he said. "Head office."

"I was."

"I was Coyle's." He said it without any heat, stepping back. By the door, on the only hook not holding a coat, was a hi-vis vest, ironed. "Depot apprenticeship. Twenty twenty-three. I could put forty-four tonnes on a bay with a hand's width either side, in the rain, at eighteen, backwards. Ask anyone. Then there's this email, and it turns out the yard doesn't need so many of us if the thing knows where everything is already." He looked at me again. "That was your lot, was it? The thing?"

"It replaced my lot."

"Yeah," he said. "Everyone says that."

His mum made tea. Her name was Dawn; she worked at a care home and had just come off nights, and she moved around that kitchen as if somebody might at any moment ask her to leave it. There was a letter on the table, propped against the fruit bowl, with a logo I didn't look at closely and a word in bold across the top that I did. *Consultation.* She lifted it to wipe underneath. She put it back. Danny, who has read more bad letters aloud than anyone alive, looked at it, and looked at her, and asked about her feet.

Nobody read it. We talked about the bus. We talked about the lift. All that time the letter sat there, and it was the loudest thing in the room.

Jack's phone lay face up by his elbow. It lit, and he glanced down, and it lit again. I'm a nosy woman and I read upside down for a living. I couldn't tell you a word of it, and I wouldn't if I could, but I could see the shape: long grey blocks on one side, one short white line after another on his. Whoever was at the other end wrote a great deal, and wrote at all hours, and never seemed to be in any hurry at all.

"Who's that?" Danny said, too lightly. The keys had come out.

"Someone who asks me questions," said Jack. He turned the phone over. "Makes a change."

Then he looked across the table at me. “So what do you do, now?”

“I write things down.”

“Who for?”

I’d spent that morning in an old man’s front room, having a breakdown over a light switch. I’d brought a keycard. I looked at the ironed vest on its hook, and at Dawn wiping round the letter, and I found I couldn’t think of a single thing to say to him that would have been worth the breath.

“He’s nineteen,” Danny said, on the stairs. It was all he said until we reached the van.

* * *

I DIDN’T SLEEP. Across the road, at ten to one, the yellow square came on. I raised my mug. It seemed the least I could do.

If I couldn’t find the door, I could at least do some honest work. I’d post the letter, the way I’d posted the manifest: let four hundred strangers look at it, some of whom were cleverer than me. I photographed it on the table. I opened the picture in the same cheap editing program I’d used to crop the stamp, and I started to black out my surname, one careful pixel at a time.

The program has a little eyedropper. You click on a colour in the picture, and it picks that colour up for your brush. I wanted black. My hand was tired, and I clicked a quarter of an inch too high, on the band.

The brush went grey. In the box at the corner of the screen, where the program tells you what it’s holding, were six characters.

6B6E70.

I looked at that for some time.

A colour on a screen isn’t a colour. I knew that, as I know how a fridge works, without having thought about it. It’s an address. It’s a place on a shelf.

THE DOOR IS GREY.

There was only one web address I knew with that house's name in it. I'd found it back in April: a dead page, blank and white, some forgotten estate agent's or conference centre's holding page, and it had told me nothing. I typed it again now, with my thumbnail between my teeth. I added a slash. I typed the six characters.

The whole screen went grey. It was the grey of the band, edge to edge, and it lit up the kitchen.

There was no name on it, and no menu. Nothing happened for about two seconds, and I've never known two seconds so thoroughly. Then a thin bar appeared in the middle of the page, with four characters beside it, *HG-68*, and a small triangle.

It was twenty to three in the morning. There was a fuchsia on the windowsill and a hole in my day. I pressed the triangle.

Hiss, first. A big room's worth of it, coming out of a laptop that had cost me two hundred pounds, with speakers the size of a fingernail. In the hiss, a clock. Someone moved in a chair, and a voice said something soft and short, the way you'd speak to a child in church.

Then a noise like a bag of cutlery thrown down a stairwell, and I jumped so hard I hit my knee on the table. A machine. It hammered and flung itself back and hammered. Behind it a woman had started to read aloud, not an old voice, not a young one, unhurried and very clear, picking words up as they arrived. *The long weather.* I stopped breathing. I'd seen those words in purple, slightly crooked, on a sheet of paper in a box. I'd never thought what they might sound like. *Does not. Hurry.* The rest went under the hammering, and the hammering stopped dead in the middle of a line.

Three notes.

I don't know how to put this down properly. I've tried several times. I was a person who owned a cheap laptop, and every sound that had ever come out of it had been thin and tinny, with a rattle in it from the left-hand side. These weren't. These had nothing in them. They were not loud. A high one, a lower one, the high one

again, and they had no business being in my kitchen, and they weren't coming from the speakers. I'd have sworn to that in court. They were just there, in the bones behind my ears. My mouth filled with water. The hairs stood up along both arms, one arm and then the other. I had the very clear and reasonable idea that someone had come into the room behind me and not yet spoken.

I didn't turn round. I'm telling you that so you know.

The hiss came back, and a man spoke, close to the microphone and very calm, an American, as if he were reading out a meter. *Note the time. Note that it was not plugged in.* A chair. Footsteps. A door that nobody closed. Then the hiss stopped halfway through a breath, and there was only the fridge.

I found that I was on my feet by the cooker, on the far side of the kitchen, and I had both hands over my ears. There was nothing left to hear. I stayed like that for some time.

When I could, I went back. I didn't sit. I leaned over the table, as you'd lean over something on a road, and I looked at the page, because there had to be more, a name, a date, something a person could reconcile.

Below the bar, very small, off-white on the grey, was a single line of capitals. It hadn't been there before, or I hadn't been able to see it.

My father had sat at a desk for thirty years. *Ask Emmanuel*, they said. *The office'd ring you at home*, Len said. There had been a phone on that desk. Somebody in that office had to pick it up first.

EVEN FOR THE ONES WHO ANSWERED THE TELEPHONE.